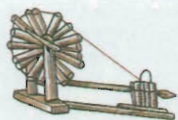


GANDHI, MOHANDAS



WHEN THE VAST AND HEAVILY populated nation of India gained independence from Britain in August 1947, one man more than any other was responsible for that achievement. Mohandas Gandhi united the different communities of India and led them to independence. He believed in non-violent protest and despised the racial violence of his homeland. He became known as Mahatma, or "great soul". Although he did not live long enough to see the results of his work, Gandhi is remembered today as the instigator of three movements crucial in the 20th century: the campaigns against racism, colonialism, and violence.



Early life

Mohandas Kamarchand Gandhi was born in Porbandar, India, in 1869. Educated in India and Britain, he trained in law and became a barrister in 1889. In 1893 he moved to work in South Africa. While there, he edited a newspaper called *Indian Opinion* and campaigned against racial injustice, forcing the South African government to grant Indians rights of permanent citizenship in 1914.

Indian nationalism

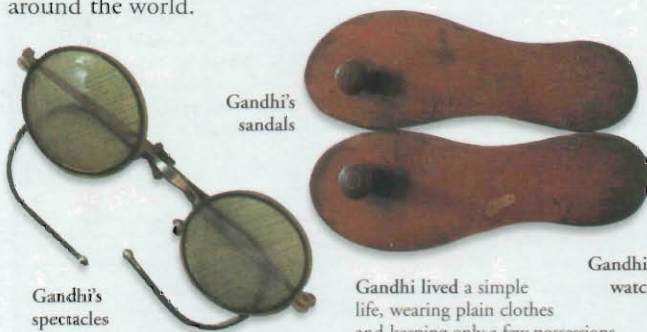
The British had controlled India since the 18th century, but many Indians wanted to govern themselves. In 1915, Gandhi returned from South Africa and became one of the leaders of the independence movement. He led many peaceful campaigns against British rule, using the tactic of non-violent civil disobedience. He called this method Satyagraha ("holding to the truth"). It was copied by many civil-rights campaigners around the world.



Gandhi with Jawaharlal Nehru, leader of the socialist wing of Congress

Congress

The Indian National Congress Party was founded in 1885. Its members wanted to increase Indian participation in government and represent all religions and cultures. During the 1920s, under the leadership of Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru, Congress took the lead in campaigning for Indian independence.



Gandhi's sandals

Gandhi's spectacles

Gandhi lived a simple life, wearing plain clothes and keeping only a few possessions.

Imprisonment

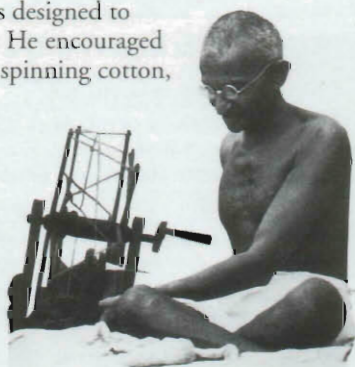
During his many campaigns, Gandhi was often imprisoned by the British for civil disobedience. But after each spell in prison, Gandhi emerged more powerful and more respected than before. His personal prestige was so high that people began to call him Mahatma, the "great soul". He alone seemed able to unite the diverse elements of the independence movement that represented the many different religions and cultures in the huge subcontinent of India.



Gandhi's watch

Social reforms

In 1937, the Indian provinces received a large measure of home rule. The Congress Party took control of seven of the 11 provinces and began to reform the country. Gandhi pushed for social, economic, and educational improvements designed to rebuild India. He encouraged crafts such as spinning cotton, because he believed that small cottage industries could help India's villages.



Gandhi spinning cotton

Independence

In 1947, India gained its independence. Hindus in the Congress Party wanted a united India, but Muslims wanted a country of their own. The country was, therefore, divided into India and Pakistan, a division Gandhi bitterly opposed.

Assassination

Gandhi took little part in the independence talks, but threatened to fast to death to protest against the violence between Hindus and Muslims. In January 1948, he was assassinated by a Hindu fanatic who resented his concern for the Muslims.

Monument at the place where Gandhi died



Salt march

The British controlled the production of salt in India. This monopoly forced up prices and was very unpopular. In 1930, Gandhi led a 320-km (200-mile) march to the sea to get his own salt and thousands joined him on the way. Gandhi was imprisoned for civil disobedience, but the march showed the power of Satyagraha.

MOHANDAS GANDHI

- 1869 Born in Porbandar, India.
- 1889 Becomes a barrister in England.
- 1891–93 Works as a lawyer in India.
- 1893–1915 Works in South Africa.
- 1920s Takes control of Congress Party with Nehru.
- 1930 Leads salt march to the sea.
- 1942 Launches Quit India campaign during World War II, and is interned until 1944.
- 1945 New British government promises independence by 1947.
- 1947 India gains its independence.
- 1948 Gandhi is assassinated.

FIND OUT
MORE

EMPIRES

HINDUISM

HUMAN
RIGHTS

INDIA,
HISTORY OF

SOUTH AFRICA,
HISTORY OF